Painted Places

Where catalogued landscape, marine and city paintings look, and how far painters went from home:
8,533 paintings and 4,740 depicted places in Wikidata

Tristan Hotham

Independent researcher
ORCID: 0000-0003-4931-9349
DOI: https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23873007

2026

Abstract

I map every painting in Wikidata that is classed as a landscape, marine painting or cityscape and that depicts an item with coordinates, after removing depicted items that are not places on the Earth (events such as sea battles, ships, and the Moon, whose coordinates lie on the lunar globe). The result is 8,533 paintings by 2,393 named painters showing 4,740 places in 102 countries. The most painted place is the Seine (228 paintings by 81 painters), followed by Paris, Lofoten, Venice and Nordland. Linking painters' birthplaces gives a distance for 7,183 paintings: the median is 231 km, 26% lie within 50 km of the birthplace and 26% more than 1,000 km away. Distances rise from a median of 48 km in the 1600s to 331 km in the 1800s, and the geography shifts from the Netherlands (62% of 1600s paintings) to Italy (37% in the 1700s) to France (27% in the 1800s). Coverage is uneven: the largest collection holds 6.6% of the paintings, 39% of them by a single painter, the ten largest 30%, and 80% of paintings show places in Europe. The map describes what has been catalogued as much as where painters went.

Keywords: landscape painting; Wikidata; cultural heritage data; art geography; painters' travel; museum collections; open data

1 Introduction

Landscape painting is about places, and many of its places are famous in their own right: Monet's Seine, Canaletto's Venice and London, the Hudson River School's Catskills. Art historians have studied painters' travels one artist or one school at a time. Linked open data now make it possible to look at many painters at once. Wikidata records, for hundreds of thousands of paintings, a creator, a date, a collection, a genre and, increasingly, what the painting depicts. When the depicted item is a river, a town or a mountain it carries coordinates. This paper uses those statements to map where catalogued landscape, marine and city paintings look, which places painters returned to, how far from their birthplaces they painted, and how the geography changed over four centuries. Because the source is a catalogue assembled by museums, projects and volunteers, the paper also measures how far a few contributors shape the result.

2 Data

I queried Wikidata (Vrandečić and Krötzsch, 2014) through the QLever SPARQL endpoint (Bast and Buchhold, 2017) on 1 November 2026 for items that are instances of painting, have a genre of

Table 1: The depicted items most often removed as not being places (painting and item pairs).

Item	Reason	Pairs
Moon	not a point on the Earth (another globe or an unknown value)	138
HMS Prince Royal	vessel	7
Four Days' Battle	event	6
Bombardment of Algiers	event	5
Battle of Solebay	event	5
Battle of Texel	event	5
Spanish Armada	event	4
Battles of Barfleur and La Hougue	event	4
Titanic	vessel	3
Raid on the Medway	event	3

landscape art, marine art or cityscape (or of three related genres, religious art, genre painting and animal painting) and depict an item with coordinates, together with the creator, inception date, image, collection and number of Wikipedia articles. The query returned 18,249 rows for 10,321 paintings. A second query returned each creator's country of citizenship and the coordinates of the place of birth, and a third the 2 paintings with a separate "coordinates of depicted place" statement. Natural Earth (Natural Earth, 2026) provides countries (today's borders), first level regions and continents.

3 Methods

3.1 Paintings and places

I keep the 8,757 paintings with at least one of the three landscape genres and set aside 1,564 that entered only through a related genre. The "depicts" property catches anything with coordinates, so I remove depicted items that are not places. The rule, applied in order, is: the coordinate must be a point on the Earth (this removes 3 items, chiefly the Moon, which appears in 138 paintings); the coordinates must be in range and not 0,0; and the item must not be an event (70 items, mostly naval battles), a vessel (19) or another non-place (2). The non-places are listed by identifier in the code after reading every depicted item with two or more paintings and a keyword scan of all labels; the build fails if the scan finds an unlisted event or ship. 224 paintings lose all their places and are dropped, leaving 8,533 paintings, 4,740 places and 11,176 painting and place pairs. Table 1 lists the most frequent exclusions.

3.2 Distances, periods and kinds of place

For each painting with a painter whose birthplace has coordinates, I compute the great circle distance from the birthplace to each depicted place and take the median across places. Broad areas (countries, first level regions, seas and oceans; 156 places) are excluded from distances when a painting also names a finer place, and paintings that name only broad areas are left out. Rivers are single points in Wikidata, so distances to rivers are approximate. Periods group inception years by hundreds (the 1800s are 1800 to 1899); paintings before 1600 are grouped together and the few after 1999 join the 1900s. Country shares split a painting equally between its places. The 100 most painted places were assigned by hand to six kinds (rivers and canals; cities, towns and villages; coasts, seas and islands; mountains, valleys and forests; buildings, bridges and squares;

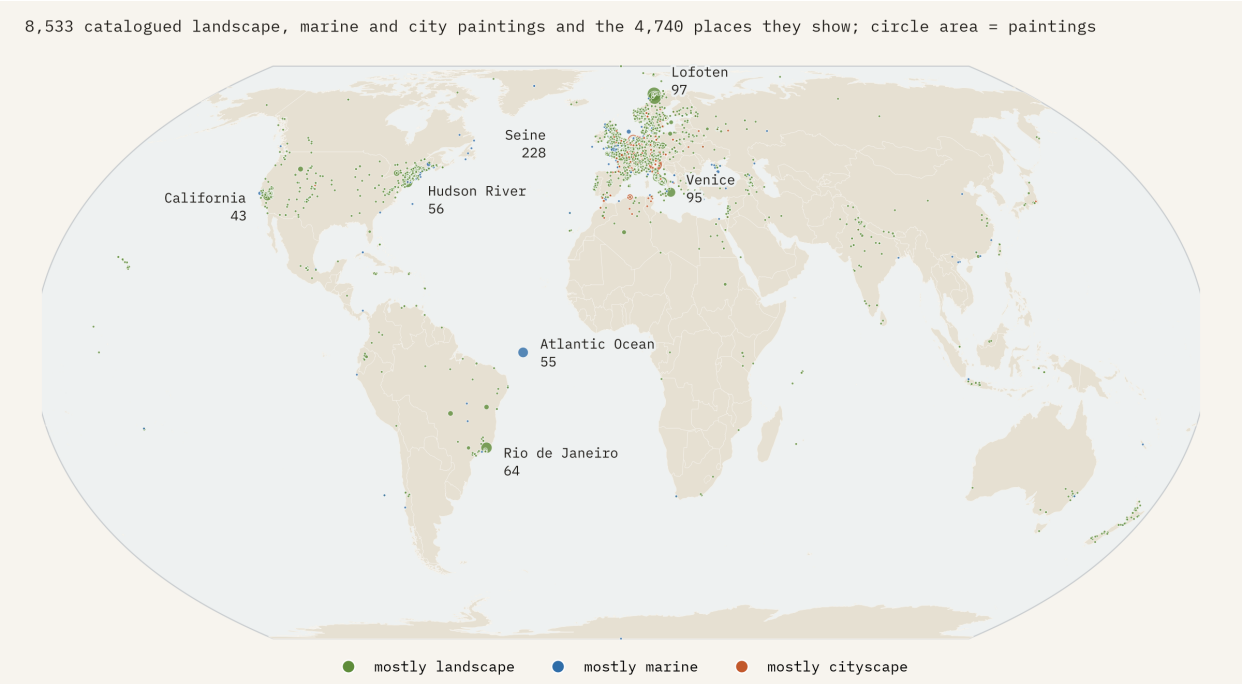


Figure 1: All 4,740 depicted places, sized by the number of paintings and coloured by the dominant genre.

regions and countries).

4 Results

4.1 The most painted places

Figure 1 maps all places and Figure 2 shows western Europe. The Seine is the most painted place, with 228 paintings by 81 painters; Monet (38), Sisley (27) and Pissarro (15) together account for 35% (Figure 3, Table 2). Among the 100 most painted places, 30 are cities, towns or villages, 20 buildings, bridges or squares, 16 rivers or canals, 13 coasts, seas or islands, 13 mountains, valleys or forests and 8 regions or countries; 8 of the top 25 are rivers, coasts or seas. The distribution has a long tail: 68% of places appear in only one painting and 155 in ten or more.

4.2 Painters and their places

Many painters concentrate on a home ground (Figure 4). The Seine accounts for 38 of Monet's 152 paintings, the Montagne Sainte-Victoire for 17 of Cézanne's 65, and Dordrecht for 24 of Jan van Goyen's 126. Turner is the exception, with 56 places among 52 paintings; Venice (13 within 8 km of its centre) outnumbers the Thames. Of Canaletto's 32 catalogued paintings, 13 show London and 15 Venice, while 36 of Francesco Guardi's 37 show Venice. The three painters with the most mapped paintings are Anna Boberg (223), Albert Bierstadt (210) and Grandma Moses (175); the ten most mapped painters account for 17% of all paintings.

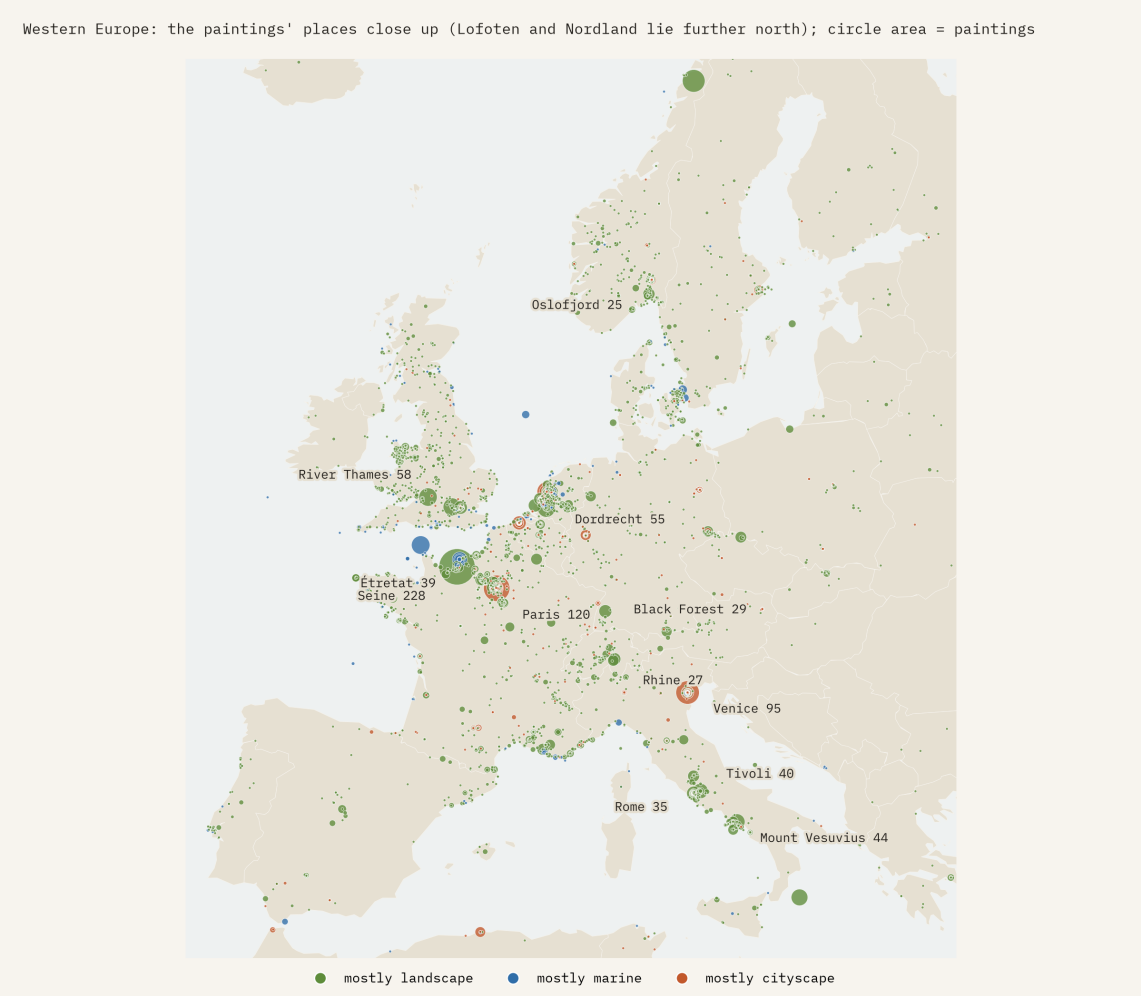


Figure 2: Western Europe in detail (European equal area projection).

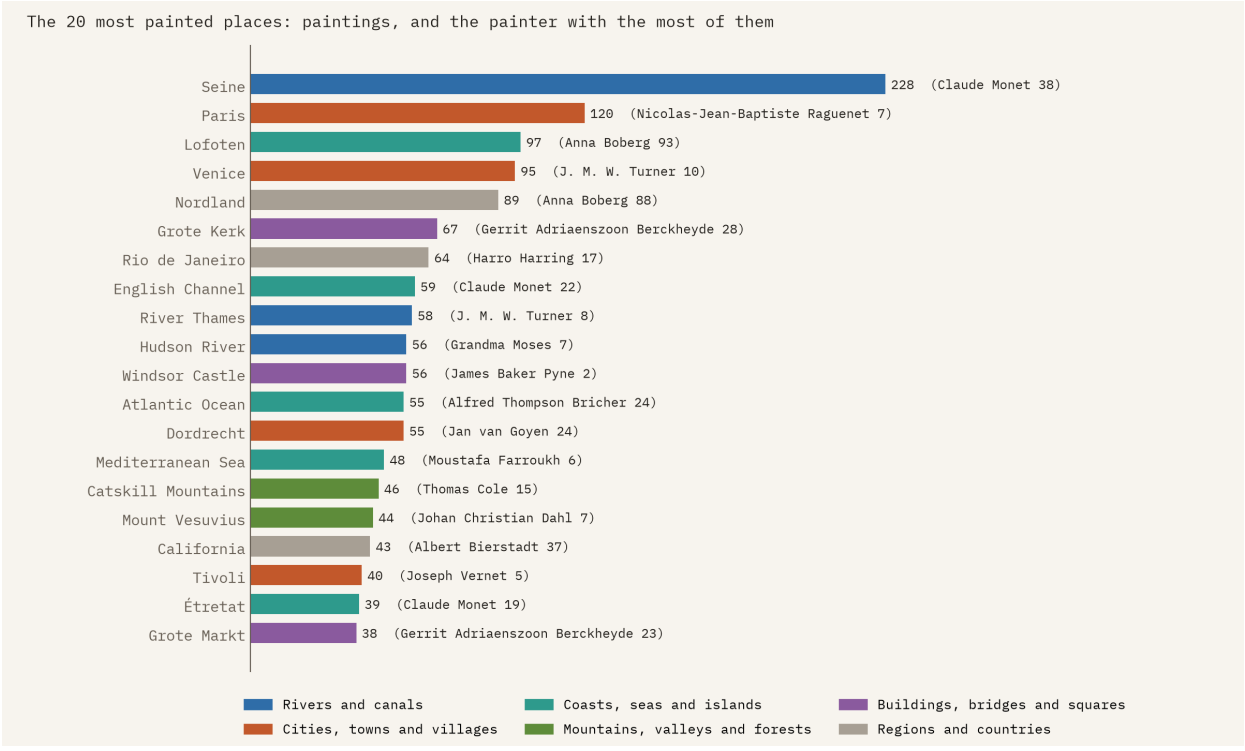


Figure 3: The 20 most painted places, coloured by kind, with the painter who painted each most often.

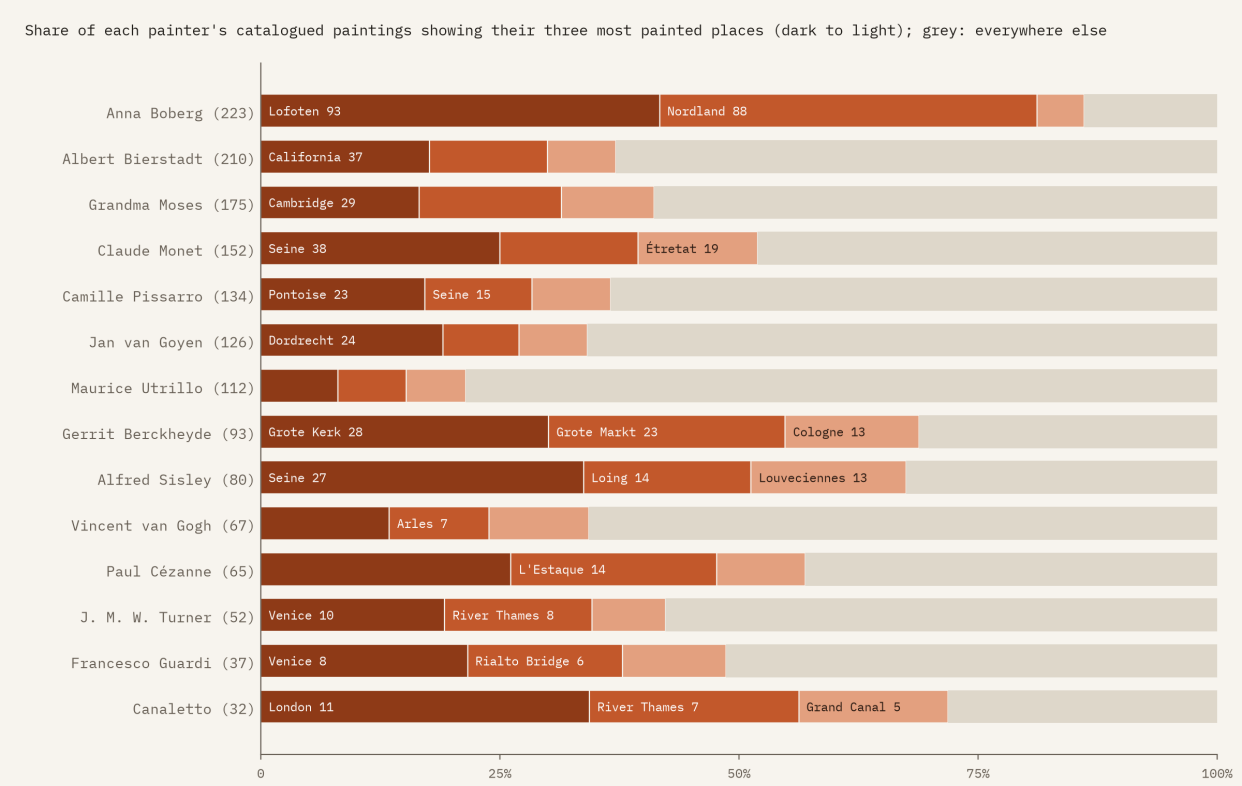


Figure 4: Share of each painter's catalogued paintings showing their three most painted places.

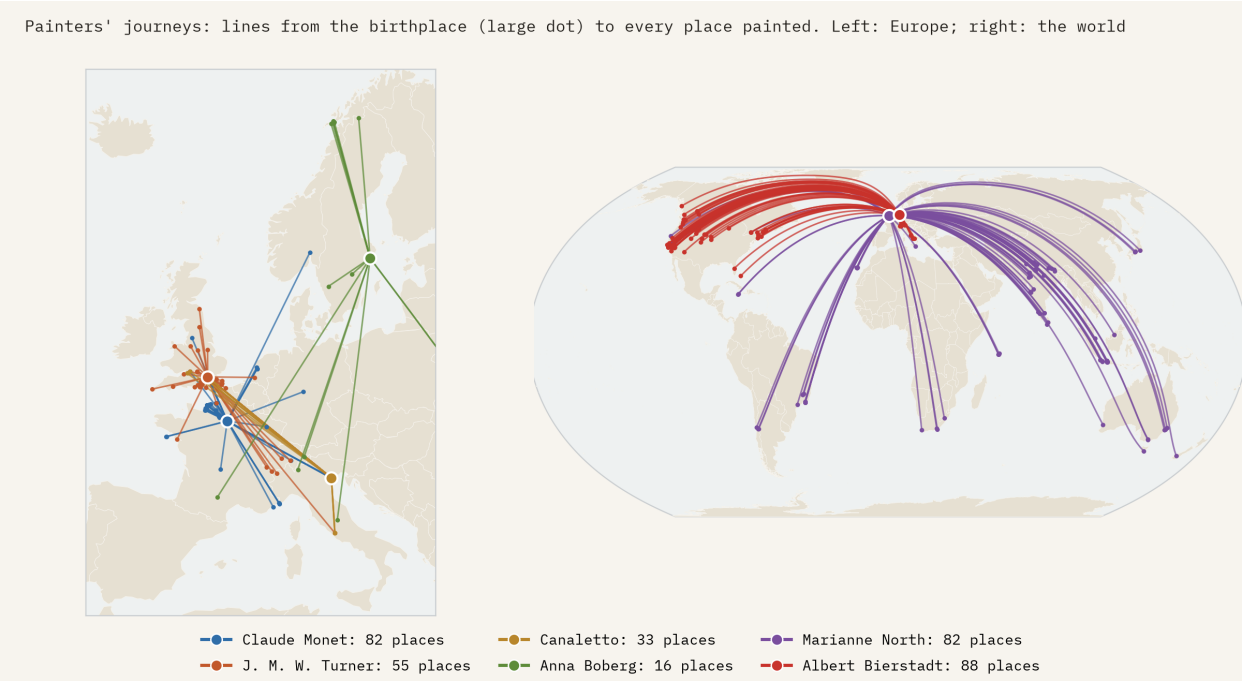


Figure 5: Lines from the birthplace to every painted place for six painters.

Table 2: The 25 most painted places: paintings, painters, and the leading painter and collection.

Place	Country	Paintings	Painters	Leading painter	Leading collection
Seine	France	228	81	Claude Monet (38)	Musée d'Orsay (73)
Paris	France	120	76	Nicolas-Jean-Baptiste Raguenet (7)	Musée d'Orsay (34)
Lofoten	Norway	97	5	Anna Boberg (93)	Nationalmuseum (93)
Venice	Italy	95	50	J. M. W. Turner (10)	Musée d'Orsay (11)
Nordland	Norway	89	2	Anna Boberg (88)	Nationalmuseum (89)
Grote Kerk	Netherlands	67	24	Gerrit Adriaenszoon Berckheyde (28)	Frans Hals Museum (11)
Rio de Janeiro	Brazil	64	19	Harro Harring (17)	Brasiliana Iconográfica (64)
English Channel	France	59	23	Claude Monet (22)	Musée d'Orsay (13)
River Thames	United Kingdom	58	30	J. M. W. Turner (8)	National Trust (10)
Hudson River	United States	56	26	Grandma Moses (7)	Brooklyn Museum (6)
Windsor Castle	United Kingdom	56	27	James Baker Pyne (2)	National Trust (50)
Atlantic Ocean	at sea	55	21	Alfred Thompson Bricher (24)	Metropolitan Museum of Art (5)
Dordrecht	Netherlands	55	14	Jan van Goyen (24)	Dordrechts Museum (4)
Mediterranean Sea	at sea	48	24	Moustafa Farroukh (6)	Sursock Museum (5)
Catskill Mountains	United States	46	14	Thomas Cole (15)	Metropolitan Museum of Art (3)
Mount Vesuvius	Italy	44	28	Johan Christian Dahl (7)	Condé Museum (9)
California	United States	43	6	Albert Bierstadt (37)	Fine Arts Museums of San Francisco (4)
Tivoli	Italy	40	30	Joseph Vernet (5)	Musée Fabre (6)
Étretat	France	39	11	Claude Monet (19)	Musée d'Orsay (5)
Grote Markt	Netherlands	38	12	Gerrit Adriaenszoon Berckheyde (23)	Frans Hals Museum (11)
Amsterdam	Netherlands	36	17	Ludolf Bakhuizen (7)	Department of Paintings of the Louvre (4)
Rome	Italy	35	25	François Marius Granet (3)	National Trust (4)
Pont Neuf	France	33	16	Camille Pissarro (5)	Musée Carnavalet (15)
Bruges	Belgium	33	22	Jan Baptist van Meunincxhove (2)	Groeningemuseum (26)
London	United Kingdom	31	17	Giovanni Antonio Canal (11)	Musée d'Orsay (4)

4.3 Distance from home

Distances are available for 7,183 paintings (84%) by 2,039 painters. The median is 231 km; 13% are within 10 km of the birthplace, 26% within 50 km, 26% beyond 1,000 km and 11% beyond 5,000 km (Figure 6). The 1600s are the most local period (median 48 km, 51% within 50 km); the median rises to 204 km in the 1700s and 331 km in the 1800s, when 31% of paintings lie more than 1,000 km from the birthplace, and falls to 232 km after 1900. By country of birth (Table 3), painters born in the Netherlands are the most local (median 47 km) and painters born in the United Kingdom (407 km) and Germany (887 km) the most distant among the large groups; British born painters' distant paintings most often show the United States and Italy. Among painters with at least 5 measurable paintings, the largest medians belong to painters who worked at the antipodes of their birthplace, and to Marianne North (94 paintings, median 8,467 km, 20 countries). Some long distances record emigration rather than travel: Bierstadt (8,140 km) and Pissarro (6,815 km) were born in Germany and on St Thomas.

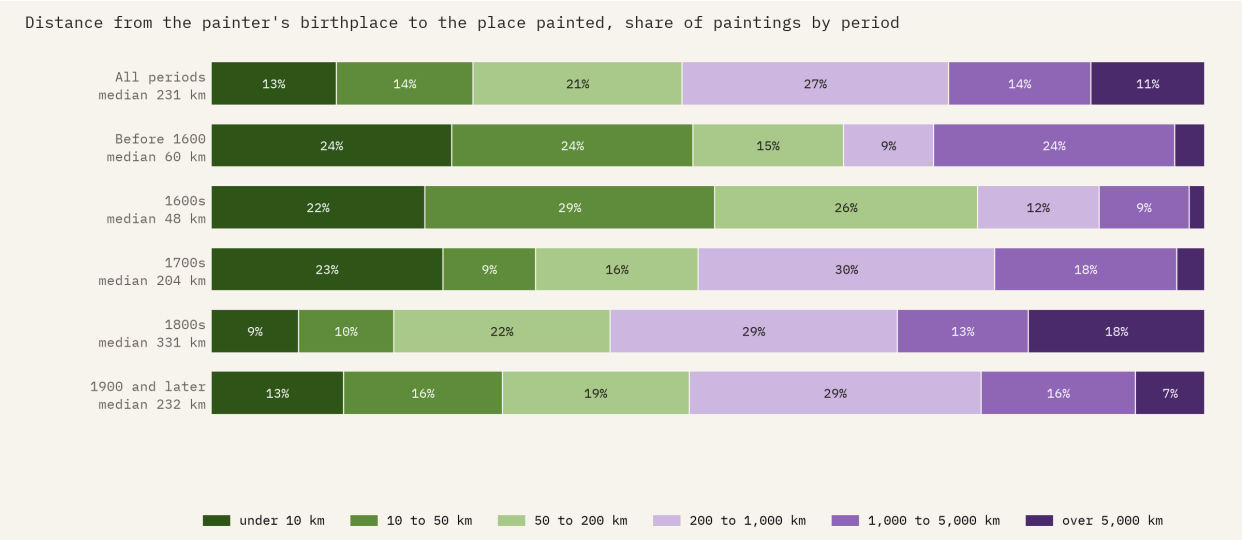


Figure 6: Distance from the painter's birthplace to the place painted, by period.

Table 3: Distance from birthplace by the painter's country of birth (today's borders; at least 80 paintings and 20 painters).

Born in	Paintings	Painters	Median km	Within 50 km	Over 1,000 km
France	1,706	456	175	30%	11%
Netherlands	1,091	243	47	51%	8%
United Kingdom	743	256	407	10%	44%
United States	681	112	279	27%	28%
Germany	497	144	887	12%	48%
Norway	393	73	258	13%	24%
Sweden	387	92	1,004	16%	52%
Italy	244	91	111	44%	19%
Denmark	232	70	156	23%	12%
Belgium	208	118	104	39%	21%
Spain	135	62	383	26%	18%
Russia	132	38	1,035	11%	61%
Poland	97	52	341	13%	23%

4.4 Through the centuries

The country of the depicted places shifts over time (Figure 7). The Netherlands account for 62% of 1600s paintings and 3% of 1800s ones; Italy for 37% of 1700s paintings, with the United Kingdom second at 23%; France for 27% of 1800s and 32% of later paintings, and the United States for 14% of 1800s paintings. Norway rises from about 1% before 1800 to 9% after 1900, or 6% without Anna Boberg.

4.5 Coverage

The paintings are linked to 1,019 collections; 15% have none recorded. The largest, Sweden's Nationalmuseum, holds 566 (6.6%), 222 of them by Anna Boberg, which places Lofoten and Nordland third and fifth among all places. The ten largest collections hold 30% of paintings and half of all collection links point to 37 collections (3.6%); 488 collections have one painting (Figure 8, Table 4). Of the 20 most painted places, 4 owe half or more of their paintings to one painter and 4 to one collection. Only 18% of paintings have a Wikipedia article, 83% have an image, and 80% show places in Europe, 12% in North America and 8% elsewhere.

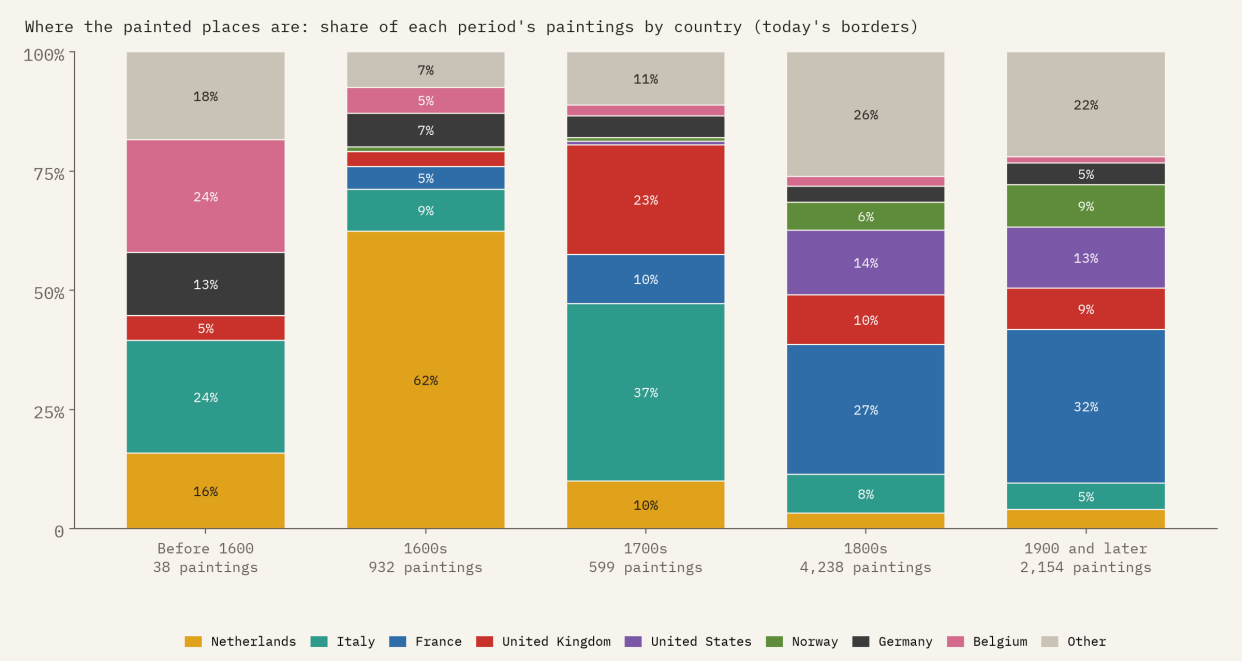


Figure 7: Share of each period's paintings by the country of the depicted place.

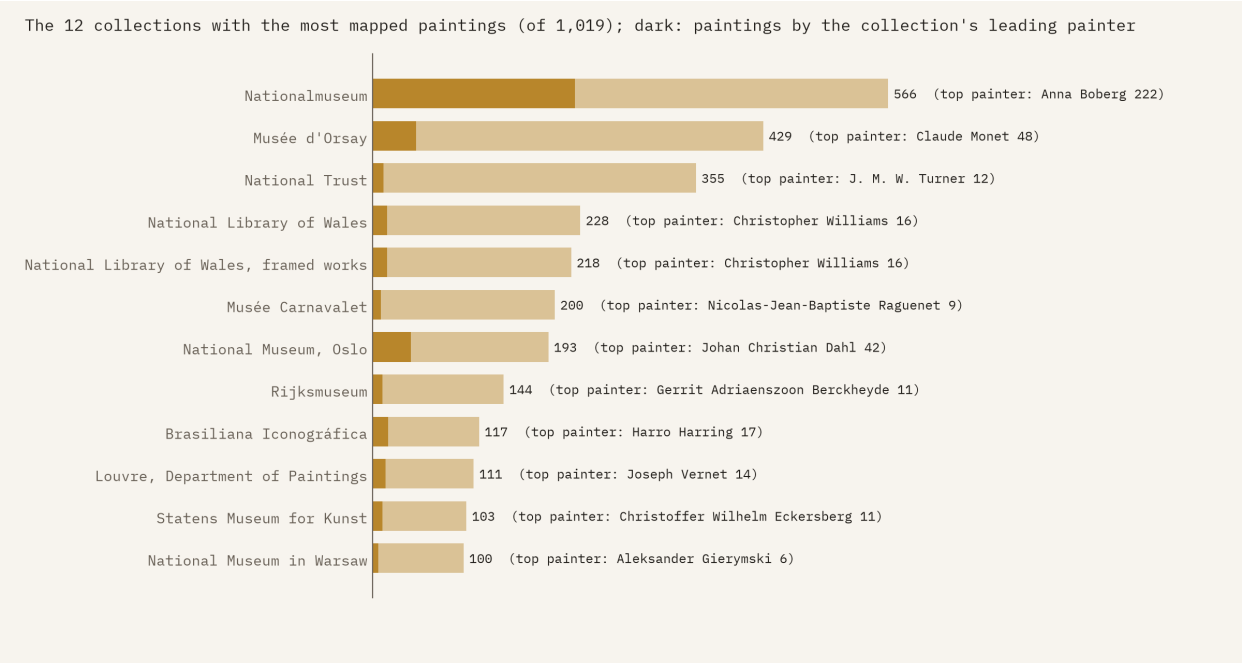


Figure 8: The 12 collections with the most mapped paintings; dark segments are the collection's leading painter.

Table 4: The 15 collections with the most mapped paintings.

Collection	Paintings	Share	Leading painter	Most painted place
Nationalmuseum	566	6.6%	Anna Boberg (222)	Lofoten (93)
Musée d'Orsay	429	5.0%	Claude Monet (48)	Seine (73)
National Trust	355	4.2%	J. M. W. Turner (12)	Windsor Castle (50)
National Library of Wales	228	2.7%	Christopher Williams (16)	Snowdon (10)
National Library of Wales Framed works of art collection	218	2.5%	Christopher Williams (16)	Snowdon (10)
Musée Carnavalet	200	2.3%	Nicolas-Jean-Baptiste Raguenet (9)	Seine (15)
National Museum of Art, Architecture and Design	193	2.3%	Johan Christian Dahl (42)	Elbe (12)
Rijksmuseum	144	1.7%	Gerrit Adriaenszoon Berckheyde (11)	Dam Square (8)
Brasiliana Iconográfica	117	1.4%	Harro Harring (17)	Rio de Janeiro (68)
Department of Paintings of the Louvre	111	1.3%	Joseph Vernet (14)	Italy (7)
Statens Museum for Kunst	103	1.2%	Christoffer Wilhelm Eckersberg (11)	Øresund (7)
National Museum in Warsaw	100	1.2%	Aleksander Gierymski (6)	Tatra Mountains (7)
Amsterdam Museum	93	1.1%	Gerrit Adriaenszoon Berckheyde (6)	Dam Square (10)
Metropolitan Museum of Art	92	1.1%	Claude Monet (7)	Atlantic Ocean (5)
Pinacoteca de São Paulo	88	1.0%	Miguelzinho Dutra (11)	Rio de Janeiro (46)

5 Limitations

First, the data are a catalogue, not a sample: a painting appears only if someone recorded its genre and the specific place it depicts, and a few institutions and painters dominate. Second, Wikidata statements can be wrong or loose (a painting tagged with a whole state or county, a river given as a single point), and I have removed only what is clearly not a place. Third, "depicts" does not prove the painter visited the place, and the birthplace is a crude proxy for home: emigrants appear as long distance travellers. Fourth, country assignments use today's borders. Fifth, the hand classification of the 100 most painted places by kind is my judgement. Sixth, only one painting in the set carries a separate "coordinates of depicted place" statement (Vermeer's View of Delft, within 1.4 km of its depicted places), so place coordinates cannot be validated at scale.

6 Conclusion

In the part of Wikidata that records what landscape paintings show, painters returned again and again to rivers, cities and coasts: the Seine above all, Paris, Venice, the Thames, the Hudson and the Dutch river towns. The catalogue captures a clear historical arc, from the painted home towns of the Dutch seventeenth century through the Italian views of the eighteenth to the French rivers and long journeys of the nineteenth. It also captures, just as clearly, the choices of those who built it: one Swedish museum's catalogue of one painter puts the north of Norway near the top of the world's painted places. Read with that in mind, open catalogue data are a promising and transparent way to study the geography of art.

Data and code availability

The interactive map is at https://maps.tristanhotham.com/painted-places/. Data and code are at https://github.com/Tristan-Hotham/painted-places and archived with this paper at https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23873007. Wikidata content is CC0. Images are not redistributed; the map links to Wikimedia Commons, where each image keeps its own licence. Derived data and text are released under CC BY 4.0 and code under the MIT licence.

AI statement

I wrote the text, with drafting and editing assistance from Claude (Anthropic), which also helped prepare the analysis code. I reviewed and checked all text and results.

References

Bast, H. and Buchhold, B. (2017) QLever: a query engine for efficient SPARQL+text search. In Proceedings of the 2017 ACM Conference on Information and Knowledge Management, 647 to 656.

Natural Earth (2026) Admin 0 countries, admin 1 states and provinces, land, 1:10m and 1:50m. Public domain. https://www.naturalearthdata.com/

Vrandečić, D. and Krötzsch, M. (2014) Wikidata: a free collaborative knowledgebase. Communications of the ACM 57(10), 78 to 85.